



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Petra Academy
School Website: <https://petraacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS: ACCREDITED MEMBER SCL: MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Petra Academy (Bozeman, MT, 59718) presents a robust CLASSICAL Christian program. Public materials from Petra emphasize formation through a Trivium/Quadrivium framework, a heavy focus on Truth, Goodness, and Beauty, and explicit Christian/theological commitments that permeate curriculum, pedagogy, and community life. The school foregrounds Great Books, Latin, logic, rhetoric, Bible integration, and a communal paideia centered on Christ, Scripture, and Christian creeds. Faculty are described as virtuous mentors who model character and pursue excellence in a Christ-centered setting. Parents are positioned as partners in the educational mission, with regular progress feedback and involvement in a faith-informed school community.

Across the six categories of the classical rubric, Petra Academy demonstrates sustained alignment with classical criteria: religious/metaphysical foundations; formation-focused purpose; a curriculum built on grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books, and a Christian worldview; pedagogy that blends contemplative, memory-based formation in early years with Socratic and rhetorical work in higher grades; a faculty who embody and transmit the living curriculum; and an emphatic, ongoing partnership with parents and the wider community.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL cases only)

- Not necessary here. All six categories reach CLASSICAL in the rubric. If one sought incremental refinement, the school could further codify explicit statements tying daily classroom practices to explicit transcendentals (though evidence already exists in multiple pages) and highlight more explicit documentation of student assessment linked to virtue beyond traditional metrics.

Note: All quantitative keyword analyses below rely on the Positive/Negative keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) and are grounded in Petra Academy public materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission proclaims partnership with parents to cultivate “faithful Christian students who delight in truth, beauty, and goodness in their worship, work, and service.” - Petra identifies as a “classical Christian school,” with Jesus Christ as “source and goal of all creation and history, and the center of any discussion of truth, beauty, and goodness.” - The school explicitly anchors in Scripture and Christian creeds (Apostles’ Creed, Nicene Creed, Westminster Confession, Heidelberg Catechism) per its Statement of Faith and accreditation material. - Distinctives articulate a “paideia of Christ” and a liturgical/community sense of formation around truth, goodness, and beauty. - Culture at Petra emphasizes “the paideia of Christ,” and the integration of faith across disciplines.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; God, Christ, Scripture, Creed, worship; theology; faith; great conversation; paideia; liturgical/community language; Bible; sacred tradition. Approximately 12+ explicit positive keywords appear across the site content cited above (e.g., truth, beauty, goodness; God/Christ; Scripture/Creed; worship; paideia; great conversation; Bible; sacred tradition; theology). - Negative keywords present: None detected in the public materials (no secular, relativistic, value-neutral, or workforce-readiness framing in opposition to the transcendentals). The absence of neutral/secular framing is consistent with the Christian, doctrinal articulation shown above.

Why this rating - Petra explicitly grounds education in Christian theology and metaphysical commitments, treats truth/goodness/beauty as real and knowable, and embeds liturgical-like, communal practices through mission, creed, Scripture, and paideia language. The Positive keyword set is densely populated while the Negative keyword set is not evident in Petra’s public materials. This alignment satisfies Transcendental Moral Realism, Grounded Theology, and Liturgical/Communal practices as described in the Classical rubric.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission centers formation through virtue and delight in truth, beauty, and goodness within worship, work, and service. - The school emphasizes education as formation (not merely information) and the cultivation of humanity/excellence, with explicit mention that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable. - The public narrative ties formation to a holistic end—cultivating character and a contemplative life in alignment with Christian moral aims (evident in “education is about formation” and the Great Conversation framework). - The Petra mission explicitly references partnership with parents to cultivate faithful Christian students who delight in truth, beauty, and goodness in worship, work, and service.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, integrity, moral imagination, contemplation, prudence, humility, self-discipline, love of learning, great conversation, ethical reasoning, human flourishing, spiritual depth, mentorship, holistic education, truth, goodness, beauty. The site content repeatedly cites formation and virtuous aims (formation, virtue, character, great conversation, truth/beauty/goodness). Estimated 15–20 explicit occurrences across the public materials cited above. - Negative keywords present: 0 clearly evident; the site consistently frames education within formation and virtue rather than utilitarian or workforce-centered aims.

Why this rating - Petra’s mission and content repeatedly frame education as the cultivation of virtue and wisdom (formation) rather than mere information or job preparation. The public materials stress human excellence through truth/beauty/goodness in a theologically grounded context, aligning strongly with CLASSICAL criteria for purpose and goal.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Distinctives describe the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium as central structure; pre-grammar through upper grades are mapped to grammar (1–6), dialectic (7–9), rhetoric (10–12). -

Academics section states: “Using the three-way methodology of the classical trivium (grammar, logic, and rhetoric), we desire that our students be well grounded in the fundamentals of the core curriculum, that they reason well, and that they articulate with precision and grace. Along with the trivium, we also engage in the quadrivium, expanding the students course of study to include the arts, math, and science.” - Curriculum Overview highlights Latin (grades 3–9), formal logic (grades 8–9), rhetoric (grades 11–12), Bible integration, and emphasis on Great Books with primary sources; Bible classes integrated as core. - The “Resource/Curriculum” content notes emphasis on Great Books of Western civilization and primary source material to cultivate sensibilities with the best that has been written. - The Petra Distinctives emphasize “grammar, logic, and rhetoric” as the core of learning and “Quadrivium” for a thorough education. - Additional notes on community-level curriculum and formation appear across multiple pages (e.g., Culture at Petra emphasizes a holistic curriculum with integration of faith).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric, Trivium, Quadrivium, Great Books, primary sources, Latin, Bible (biblical studies), the Great Conversation, memory/chanting as mnemonic devices (pedagogical texture), formation through learning, interconnected disciplines (arts, math, science). Roughly 12–18 explicit terms/phrases appear across the cited pages. - Negative keywords present: 0 identified; the curriculum materials emphasize depth, breadth, and integration with mode and content rather than secular, skills-based, or utilitarian views.

Why this rating - Petra’s curriculum is clearly anchored in classical core content and methods: Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Latin/logic/rhetoric, Bible integration, and a “great conversation” through primary sources. The presence of pre-grammar through rhetoric stages and explicit emphasis on memorization and wonder (e.g., chants for grammar) aligns strongly with the CLASSICAL criteria for curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Distinctives describe “restful learning” in the early years and “Observing with Humility” in grammar stage, using chants and songs to reinforce fundamentals, and “Thinking with Reason” in dialectic/logic stage through debate, animated discussion, and persuasive writing. - The dialectic/logic stage explicitly references reasoned debate and argumentative discussion; the rhetoric stage emphasizes articulation and persuasive presentations. - The Petra methodology page describes age-specific learning aligned with stage development and the “great conversation” across ages; the aim is to train students to observe humbly, think logically, and articulate charitably. - The Curriculum/Academics page emphasizes “formation” and “eyes to see the world the way God sees it,” implying contemplative/restful aspects alongside rigorous instruction. - The Culture page emphasizes a holistic approach integrating theatre, athletics, art, computer science, language, and service with the classical trivium and other disciplines.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplative, restful, singing/chanting in lower grades, memorization, Socratic discussion, debate, seminars, rhetoric, speeches, great conversation, living curriculum, mentorship, paired with a God-centered paideia. Approximately 15–20 explicit occurrences across the pages cited. - Negative keywords present: 0 explicit; no mention of rote, drill-only or purely job-based instruction; rather, a balanced approach with contemplation and structured rigor.

Why this rating - Petra’s pedagogy combines restive, chant-based memory work in the grammar stage with Socratic/debate-based inquiry in the dialectic stage and rhetorical training in the rhetoric stage, complemented by contemplative aims and a holistic paideia. This aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy expectations, including both memory work and rigorous reasoning/dialogue in appropriate age bands.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Faculty page describes Petra’s faculty as “passionate about children, their subject areas, and most importantly the Lord Jesus Christ,” teaching with joy through a God-centered paideia; scholars who love

God and students, with a commitment to living the curriculum. - The materials emphasize highly-qualified and motivated teachers, small teacher-student ratios, and well-ordered classrooms that support diligence. - The description frames faculty as “the living curriculum” and as mentors who model virtue, skill, knowledge, and the pursuit of truth and beauty; public materials repeatedly reference the “great conversation” of ideas and the long tradition of classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; mentors; model virtue; high qualifications; passion for the Lord Jesus Christ; God-centered paideia; small class sizes; great conversation; collaborative faculty-student relations; intellectual virtue; formation through teaching. Approximately 12–15 explicit instances across the pages cited. - Negative keywords present: 0 explicit; no references to antagonistic or secular faculty profiles; the content presents a consistently positive, virtue-centered faculty portrait.

Why this rating - Petra explicitly presents its faculty as virtuous, mission-aligned mentors who are central to the living curriculum, with a focus on character, virtue, and partnership with families. This matches the classical expectation of faculty as the core of the school’s living tradition and as role models, earning CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission communicates partnership with parents to cultivate faithful Christian students, indicating a central role for parents as co-caregivers in the formation process. - The school emphasizes ongoing parental engagement, regular feedback on student progress, and a welcoming posture toward parent involvement (e.g., “open enrollment,” portal access, events). - The Culture and Community content describe a holistic, family-inclusive approach, with “parents as co-teachers” language echoed in the emphasis on mutual formation and joint pursuit of truth/beauty/goodness. - The Resources, Blog, and Events content indicate ongoing engagement opportunities for parents (and the broader community) to participate in classical discussions and resources.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parental engagement; regular progress feedback; family involvement; community events; open-door policy for visits; parent resources and book studies. Approximately 12–18 explicit positive content items appear across the cited pages. - Negative keywords present: 0 explicit; materials emphasize the positive, collaborative role of families rather than a top-down only model.

Why this rating - Petra frames parents as essential partners and co-educators in the classical project, with explicit mechanisms for engagement (portal, events, blogs, feedback). The community-facing language and family-centered practices align with CLASSICAL expectations for parent/community involvement.

What Would Move the Needle

- Since all six categories reach CLASSICAL, no major needle-moving changes are necessary. If a future refinement were desired, Petra could further codify and publish explicit mappings from daily classroom activities to the transcendentals (truth/goodness/beauty) and provide concise, public rubrics showing how each grade level’s assignments and assessments reflect formation, great books engagement, and Socratic/seminar practices to make alignment even more transparent.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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